Topic 13 — Folk (लोक) Culture

Covers syllabus (click to expand)

Folk Arts | Folk Traditions | Folk Beliefs | Folk Culture of India | Handloom (हथकरघा) | Handicrafts | GI Tagged Crafts

Sources: NCERT An Introduction to Indian Art (Class 11), Ministry of Textiles, DC Handicrafts, GI Registry (DPIIT), UNESCO ICH, UPPCS Prelims 2018–2025 **Last verified:** August 2026

Current Affairs

- The **e-Pehchan** (ई-पहचान) portal for handloom workers' digital IDs opened in **January 2025**.
- In **December 2025** Uttar Pradesh (उत्तर प्रदेश) led the GI count with **81** tags. India had **445** handicraft (हस्तशिल्प) GIs.
- The **12th** National Handloom Day fell on **7 August 2026**. Sant Kabir (कबीर) and the National Handloom Awards sit with that Day.
- **NHDP** and **RMSS** remain the two handloom umbrella schemes.

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13.1 Folk Arts

Folk arts are community-owned visual and craft forms. They belong to a region and a ritual. They are not a classical akademi school.

- Folk art is made for festivals, weddings, harvests and livelihood. Local clay, dye, cloth and paper keep it cheap and regional.
- Transmission is oral. Mothers, artisan guilds (श्रेणी) and village experts teach it. There is no SNA-style syllabus.
- **Madhubani (Mithila)** belongs to **Bihar**. Women paint walls and paper with double line, bright fill and Kohbar marriage symbols. It has a **GI**. It is **not** a UNESCO ICH named element.
- **Warli** belongs to **Maharashtra**. White rice-paste stick figures sit on red ochre mud. Geometry is circle, triangle and square.
- **Pattachitra** belongs to **Odisha** (Puri (पुरी)–Raghurajpur). Cloth or palm-leaf panels tell Jagannath (जगन्नाथ) myths.
- **Phad** belongs to **Rajasthan** (थार). It is a long cloth scroll of Pabuji or Devnarayan. **Bhopas** sing it.
- **Gond** belongs to **Madhya Pradesh**. Pardhan artists build animals and spirits from dotted lines. **Jangarh Singh Shyam** is the named modern master.
- **Kalamkari** belongs to **Andhra Pradesh**. The name is pen-work. **Srikalahasti** is freehand temple painting. **Machilipatnam** is block-print trade (पण्याध्यक्ष) cloth. The cloth is **cotton**, not Himalayan wool.

- **Sanjhi** belongs to **Mathura–Vrindavan, Uttar Pradesh. It is stencilled paper-cutting on Yamuna (यमुना) ghats, tied to Krishna (कृष्णा) and Pitru Paksha. It now has a GI.
- **Phulkari** belongs to **Punjab**. Flower embroidery sits on an odhani or shawl.
- **Pithora** is a sacred ritual wall painting tradition of the Rathwa and Bhilala tribes in Gujarat and Madhya Pradesh, characterized by vivid depictions of horses and the tutelary deity Pithora Baba.
- **Saura** belongs to **Odisha**. The wall icon is *idital*. Do not call it Warli.
- **Cheriyal** belongs to **Telangana**. It is a narrative scroll.
- **Kalighat painting** originated in 19th-century Calcutta (West Bengal) around the Kalighat temple, evolving into popular bazaar scroll watercolours depicting Hindu deities and sharp satirical sketches of colonial babu society.
- **Rogan** belongs to **Kutch, Gujarat**. Castor-oil paint is laid with a stick or stylus.
- **Aipan** belongs to **Uttarakhand** (उत्तराखंड). White rice-paste geometry covers floors and walls.
- **Mandana** belongs to Rajasthan (and adjoining MP). White chalk floor-and-wall patterns mark harvest.
- **Lippan Kaam** (mud and mirror relief work) is the traditional decorative mural (भित्ति) art of the Rabari community in Kutch, Gujarat.
- **Sujni** embroidery belongs to **Bihar**, not Maharashtra.
- Nautanki and Raslila are folk **performance**, not wall painting. Visual folk art is still the painting and craft list above.

> **Logic:** Madhubani = Bihar. Warli = Maharashtra. Sanjhi = Mathura Uttar Pradesh. Never swap the three.

13.2 Folk Traditions

Folk tradition is living custom. It follows season, life-cycle, fair, and oral epic. The language is local and flexible.

- Folk tradition is the calendar behind folk art. It is not a Sanskrit canon.
- Agrarian rites follow sowing and harvest. Named examples are Bihu (बिहू), Onam (ओणम) and Nuakhai (नुआखाइ).
- Life-cycle rites use folk art. Madhubani is painted for a wedding. Sanjhi is cut for Pitru Paksha.
- Oral epics live with bards. **Pandavani** (पांडवानी) is Chhattisgarh Mahabharata (महाभारत) song (सोंग). **Teejan Bai** (तीजन बाई) is the named singer. Phad bhopas carry Rajasthan's Pabuji.
- Folk guru-shishya exists, but it is informal. Family, caste guild and village elder replace a classical academy.
- Women carry several visual traditions. Madhubani, Phulkari and Sanjhi are the named cases.
- **Surajkund International Crafts Mela** is at Faridabad in **Haryana**. It is a **February** government crafts fair. It is not Rajasthan and not Delhi.
- **Pushkar Fair** is at Pushkar, Ajmer (अजमेर), **Rajasthan**. It is a Kartik camel and livestock fair. It is not a 4-site Kumbh.

- **Pushkar Kumbh** is a different event. It is at **Keshav Prayag (प्रयाग), Mana** (Chamoli (चमोली)) in **Uttarakhand**. It ran in **May 2025**. It is not Rajasthan and not UP.
- **Sonepur** cattle fair belongs to **Bihar**.
- **Taj Mahotsav** is a crafts-and-culture show at **Agra, Uttar Pradesh.
- Village syncretism is common. A fair can mix Hindu and Muslim custom without becoming a classical school.

> **Logic:** The May 2025 **Pushkar Kumbh** was held at Mana / Keshav Prayag in **Uttarakhand only**. Rajasthan owns the **Pushkar camel fair**, not that May Kumbh.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2025, Q97

In May 2025, Pushkar Kumbh Mela (कुंभ मेला) 2025 was organized in which of the following States?

1. Rajasthan
2. Uttar Pradesh
3. Uttarakhand

A. 1 and 2 B. Only 3 C. 2 and 3 D. Only 1

Show answer

Ans: B — Only 3. Held at **Keshav Prayag, Mana**, **Uttarakhand**. Pushkar town in Rajasthan is a different Kartik camel fair. Not UP.

13.3 Folk Beliefs

Folk belief is the village and tribal spirit world. It supplements scripture. Match each belief with its practice.

- Folk belief explains illness, luck and weather through local deities, ancestors and omens. It sits beside Hindu, Muslim or tribal formal doctrine. It does not replace it.
- A **Gramdevta** is the village protector. A **Kuldevi** is the clan goddess. An annual jatra (यात्रा) honours them.
- **Shitala** is a folk smallpox / fever goddess. **Bhumia** is a soil guardian in some belts.
- **Nag Panchami** is pan-India snake worship. Milk is offered to snake images and holes. Agrarian fear of bite mixes with Shesha myth.
- **Chhath** is sun worship of the **UP–Bihar** belt. It is not a Ganga-only rite and not a Shiva festival.
- **Vat Savitri** honours the banyan. Tree, river and hill cults are nature-folk, not Vedanta (उत्तर मीमांसा).
- Ancestor rites include **Pitru Paksha**. Tribal variants include **Sarhul** (सरहुल) and coastal **Bhuta kola**.
- **Nazar** is the evil-eye complex. Black dots, lemon-chilli hangings and mirchi smoke are the warding kit.
- **Ojha / Gunia** are folk healers of the UP–Bihar–Jharkhand belt. This is not classical Ayurveda.
- **Sarna** belongs to Jharkhand. Sacred groves are **Jaherthan**.

- **Donyi-Polo** belongs to Arunachal. It is sun-moon worship.
- **Sanamahi** belongs to Manipur. It is an indigenous deity layer older than later Hindu overlay.
- Tribal cosmology is indigenous. Village Hindu folk belief is syncretic. Do not collapse the two.
- Warli walls remember **Palaghata**. Gond panels remember forest *bada dev*. Madhubani Kohbar marks fertility.

> **Logic:** Nag Panchami = snake. Chhath = Surya. Gramdevta = village protector**, not a Vedic rishi.

13.4 Folk Culture of India

Folk culture of India is many regional micro-cultures. Agrarian rhythm and oral craft sit in classical, folk, and tribal layers.

- Indian folk culture is not one system. Shared harvest calendars and oral making hold the regions together.
- Classical culture is court and temple, Sanskrit or Persian (फ़ारसी), and a written canon.
- Folk culture is community, oral, and in the local language.
- Tribal culture is Adivasi (आदिवासी) identity and forest economy. Gond, Warli and Sarna sit here, not in Bharatanatyam.
- In northern India, folk culture is exemplified by the **Braj** Krishna devotional landscape and traditional **Ramlila** performances.
- In eastern India, folk traditions are headlined by **Madhubani** painting and the riverine **Chhath Puja**.
- In western India, community celebration is anchored by Gujarati **Garba** (गरबा) and Maharashtra's tribal **Warli** painting.
- In southern India, vibrant folk expressions include Andhra's **Kalamkari** textiles and Kerala's ritualistic **Theyyam** (तेय्यम) dance.
- In north-eastern India, folk life revolves around Assam's agricultural **Bihu** (बिहू) and indigenous bamboo-cane craftsmanship.
- In the central tribal belt, artistic traditions are led by **Gond** painting and Chhattisgarh's Mahabharata narrative balladeering, **Pandavani**.
- **Ramlila** is UNESCO ICH **2008**. The living belt is North India with a **UP** centre (Ramnagar–Varanasi, Braj).
- **Garba of Gujarat** is UNESCO ICH **2023**.
- **Chhau** (छऊ) (2010) and **Kalbelia** (कालबेलिया) (2010) are folk/tribal performance listings. Bharatanatyam is **not** a named UNESCO ICH element.
- Kumbh Mela is UNESCO ICH **2017**. Full four-site fact lives with festivals. Folk culture only needs the year.
- **IGNCA Janapada (जनपद) Sampada** documents folk and tribal culture.
- Seven **Zonal Cultural Centres** tour folk troupes. **North Central ZCC** sits at **Prayagraj**, not Lucknow.
- UP heartland belts are **Braj** (Mathura–Vrindavan), **Awadh** (अवध) (Lucknow embroidery and composite culture), and eastern UP's Chhath–Bhojpuri continuum.

- UP craft towns are workplaces, not museum labels. Moradabad, Firozabad, Khurja and Bhadohi are the named cluster set.

> **Logic:** Ramlila UNESCO 2008 = UP/North. Garba UNESCO 2023 = Gujarat**. North Central ZCC =** Prayagraj**.

13.5 Handloom

Handloom is cloth woven by hand on a loom. The ministry is **Textiles**. A regional weave is a cultural identity.

- Handloom is India's largest cottage industry after agriculture. Work is mostly rural and household-based.
- The weaver moves the shuttle. A **powerloom** is machine-driven mass weave. Cheap powerloom copies are the livelihood threat.
- **Khadi** must be **hand-spun and hand-woven. KVIC** runs khadi. KVIC sits under **MSME**, not Textiles.
- Handloom yarn may be mill-spun. That is why khadi is the stricter Swadeshi fact.
- Nodal body for handloom is the **Development Commissioner (Handlooms)** under **Textiles**. Culture does not run the loom schemes.
- **NHDC** supplies hank yarn. Weaver Service Centres upgrade skill and design.
- **National Handloom Day** is **7 August**. It marks the **Swadeshi** (स्वदेशी) launch of **7 August 1905**. It is not 15 August and not 2 October.
- The Day was first observed in **2015**. The **12th** Day fell on **7 August 2026**.
- **Handloom Mark** (**2006**) certifies that the cloth is **hand-woven**.
- **India Handloom Brand** (**2015**) is a quality-and-authenticity mark against powerloom fakes.
- Two live umbrellas are the **National Handloom Development Programme (NHDP)** and the **Raw (रॉ) Material Supply Scheme (RMSS)**.
- Weaver **MUDRA** / concessional credit is the loan fact. **Hathkargha Samvardhan Sahayata** funds loom upgrades.
- **Sant Kabir Award** is the highest honour for a **handloom weaver**. It is not Shilp Guru.
- **Banarasi Brocade** is the **Varanasi, UP** flagship. Gold-silver zari on silk is the look.
- **Chanderi** belongs to **Madhya Pradesh**.
- **Kanchipuram (कांचीपुरम) / Kanjeevaram** silk belongs to **Tamil Nadu (तमिलनाडु)**.
- **Paithani** belongs to **Maharashtra**.
- **Baluchari** belongs to **West Bengal**.
- **Pochampally Ikat** belongs to **Telangana**.
- **Patan Patola** is Gujarat double ikat.
- **Muga** and **Eri** silks belong to **Assam**.
- **Sambalpuri** ikat belongs to **Odisha**.
- **Maheshwari** belongs to **MP**.
- **Bhagalpur** tussar belongs to **Bihar**.

- **Uppada Jamdani** belongs to **Andhra Pradesh**, not Karnataka.
- **Puthukkuli / Poothkuli** shawls are **Toda** embroidery of the Nilgiris, **Tamil Nadu**.

> **Logic:** 7 August = Handloom Day**. Ministry =** Textiles. Khadi ≠ ordinary handloom**.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2019, Q44

Which of the following statements about India's largest Charkha (चरखा) is/are true?

1. It was inaugurated in Noida.
2. It is made of used plastic waste.

A. Only 1 B. Only 2 C. Both 1 and 2 D. Neither 1 nor 2

Show answer

Ans: C — Both 1 and 2. Noida (Sector 94), plastic-waste charkha, Gandhi (गांधी) 150th eve. Swadeshi symbol, not a GI craft.

13.6 Handicrafts

A handicraft is a handmade decorative or useful object. DC Handicrafts (हस्तशिल्प आयुक्तालय) sits under **Textiles**. Learn town and material together.

- Handicraft is pottery, metal, wood, glass, embroidery, leather and bamboo. It is not factory (फैक्टरी) plastic and it is not, by itself, a loom-woven saree.
- **Development Commissioner (Handicrafts)** sits under **Ministry of Textiles**. Culture does not administer the artisan card.
- **EPCH** (Export Promotion Council for Handicrafts) markets exports.
- Live umbrellas are the **National Handicrafts Development Programme (NHDP)** and the **Comprehensive Handicrafts Cluster Development Scheme (CHCDS)** — the mega-cluster route.
- **PEHCHAN** (**2016**) is the Aadhaar-linked **handicraft artisan** identity card. It is not the 2025 handloom e-Pehchan portal.
- **Shilp Guru** is the highest honour for a **handicraft** master. National Awards sit below it.
- **SFURTI** is an **MSME** cluster scheme. It can touch crafts. It is not a Textiles DC scheme.
- **Chikankari** is **Lucknow, UP** white-thread embroidery on fine cotton or muslin.
- **Zardozi** is metallic-thread embroidery. Lucknow, Delhi and Varanasi all work it. Do not swap it with Chikankari.
- **Moradabad** is India's brass / metal-craft city. It is not the glass city.
- **Firozabad** is the glass and bangle city.
- **Khurja** (Bulandshahr) is glazed pottery.
- **Bhadohi–Mirzapur (मिर्ज़ापुर)** is the hand-knotted **carpet** belt. Bhadohi is Sant Ravidas Nagar.
- **Kannauj** is **attar** / perfume.
- **Saharanpur** is wood carving.

- **Agra** is marble inlay (pietra dura (पिएत्रा ड्यूरा) memory).
- **Meerut** (मेरठ) is scissors (and a GI bugle).
- **Nizamabad black pottery** belongs to **Azamgarh**, UP.
- **Pilkhuwa** hand-block print belongs to **Hapur**, UP.
- **Mainpuri Tarkashi** is brass-wire inlay on wood.
- **Blue Pottery** belongs to **Jaipur, Rajasthan**. It is not Lucknow.
- **Bidriware** belongs to **Bidar, Karnataka**. Silver (रूपक) inlay sits on a black alloy.
- **Dhokra** (ढोकरा) is tribal lost-wax (मोम-विधि) bell-metal of the Bastar belt (Chhattisgarh, with Odisha / Jharkhand / Bengal cousins). It is not a Chola (चोल) temple bronze (कांस्य).
- **Channapatna** lacquer toys belong to **Karnataka**.
- **Pipli** appliqué belongs to **Odisha**.
- **Molela** terracotta (पकी मिट्टी) plaques belong to **Rajasthan. Bankura** terracotta horses belong to **West Bengal**.
- Jammu & Kashmir's hallmark handicrafts are world-renowned **papier-mâché** and hand-woven **Pashmina** / Kani shawls.
- **Venushilpa** by Chitracharya **Upendra Maharathi** is a book on **bamboo art**, not painting.

> **Logic:** Moradabad = brass. Firozabad = glass. Khurja = pottery. Bhadohi = carpet. Blue Pottery = Jaipur**.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2019, Q117

The book 'Venushilpa' by Chitracharya Upendra Maharathi relates to which of the following form of arts?

A. Jewellery B. Painting C. Bamboo art D. Marble curving

Show answer

Ans: C — Bamboo art. Painting is the trap option.

13.7 GI Tagged Crafts

A GI tag is a place-name plus a traditional quality. It is a community right. The ministry is **Commerce (DPIIT)**, not Culture.

- A GI tag stops outsiders from selling a fake regional name. Only authorised producers of that place may use it.
- The law is the **Geographical Indications of Goods (Registration and Protection) Act, 1999**. Registration began **2003–04**.
- The **GI Registry** is at **Chennai**. The nodal ministry is **Commerce and Industry (DPIIT)**. It is **not** Culture and **not** Textiles.
- India passed the Act to meet **WTO–TRIPS** obligations.
- Validity is **10 years**, renewable.

- The **first** Indian GI is **Darjeeling Tea (2004)**. It is not Banarasi saree and not Basmati.
- A GI is community property. A **trademark** is a company (कंपनी)'s brand. Banarasi Brocade GI is not Fabindia's mark.
- **Banarasi Brocade and Sarees** — Varanasi.
- **Lucknow Chikankari** — Lucknow.
- **Lucknow Zardozi** — Lucknow.
- **Bhadohi carpets** — Sant Ravidas Nagar.
- **Moradabad Metal Craft** — Moradabad.
- **Khurja Pottery** — Bulandshahr.
- **Firozabad Glass** — Firozabad.
- **Kannauj Perfume (Attar)** — Kannauj.
- **Mathura Sanjhi Craft** — Mathura.
- **Saharanpur Wood Carving** — Saharanpur.
- **Pilkhuwa Hand Block Print** — Hapur.
- **Nizamabad Black Pottery** — Azamgarh.
- **Mainpuri Tarkashi** — Mainpuri.
- **Agra marble / stone inlay** — Agra.
- **Banaras Gulabi Meenakari (गुलाबी मीनाकारी)** — Varanasi enamel metal.
- **Madhubani Painting GI** — Bihar.
- **Warli Painting GI** — Maharashtra.
- **Pattachitra GI** — Odisha.
- **Kalamkari GI** — Andhra.
- **Pochampally Ikat GI** — Telangana.
- **Kanchipuram Silk GI** — Tamil Nadu.
- **Paithani GI** — Maharashtra.
- **Patan Patola GI** — Gujarat.
- **Blue Pottery of Jaipur GI** — Rajasthan.
- **Bidriware GI** — Karnataka.
- **Muga Silk GI** — Assam.
- **Phulkari GI** — Punjab.
- **Sujni GI** — Bihar, not Maharashtra.
- **Uppada Jamdani GI** — Andhra Pradesh, not Karnataka.
- **Puthukkuli / Toda embroidery** — Tamil Nadu.
- UP leads India's GI count in recent tallies. Craft and textile GIs are the fastest-growing class. Food and agri GIs are not this topic's matching list.
- UP **ODOP** (One District One Product) rides the same craft geography. ODOP is a promotion scheme. It is not the GI Act.

> **Logic:** GI ministry (वाणिज्य) = Commerce. Registry = Chennai. First GI = Darjeeling Tea 2004. Banarasi + Chikankari = Uttar Pradesh.

PYQ — UPSC (संघ लोक सेवा आयोग) Prelims 2018

Consider the following pairs:

Craft — Heritage of

1. Puthukkuli shawls — Tamil Nadu
2. Sujni embroidery — Maharashtra
3. Uppada Jamdani saris — Karnataka

Which of the pairs given above is/are correct?

A. 1 only B. 1 and 2 C. 3 only D. 2 and 3

Show answer

Ans: A — 1 only. Sujni = **Bihar**. Uppada Jamdani = **Andhra Pradesh**.
